How do plants get food?

BACKGROUND

nutrients (say 'nu-tree-ants') – substances that provide animals and plants with the energy essential for growth and life

Just like animals, plants need food to produce energy, so they can grow and survive. Plants have two main types of food: organic and inorganic. Organic means coming from living things, and inorganic means coming from things that are not living.

Inorganic foods are the minerals that plants get from the earth. They are nutrients that are found in the soil that the plants grow in. Minerals in the soil are dissolved in water and sucked up (absorbed) by the plant's roots. In areas where the soil is poor quality – either with too few nutrients or too many of one kind of nutrient – humans can add fertilisers to give plants more inorganic nutrients.

Green plants can also make their own **organic food**, using sunlight and two important inorganic nutrients: carbon dioxide and water. The name for the organic food that plants make out of inorganic nutrients is glucose. The process of making glucose is called photosynthesis.

☞ **1** Why might plants need fertiliser? Complete the sentence.

Plants sometimes need fertiliser because _____

_____.

2 Fill in the gaps using words from the word bank.

a) Plants take in _____ from the soil when they _____ water from the soil. This process is called absorption.

b) Plants produce _____ from _____, sunlight and water. This process is called photosynthesis.

Word bank

absorb

carbon dioxide

glucose

minerals

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ISBN 978 1 92571 063 2

How do plants get food? CONT'D

3 Mark each of the following things as organic or inorganic.

a)	plants	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
b)	carbon dioxide	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
c)	glucose	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
d)	soil	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
e)	water	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
f)	sunlight	☐ organic	☐ inorganic
g)	oxygen	☐ organic	☐ inorganic

4 **a)** What are the two inorganic nutrients that green plants need to make the organic food called glucose?

_____

b) Green plants turn these ingredients into what?

_____

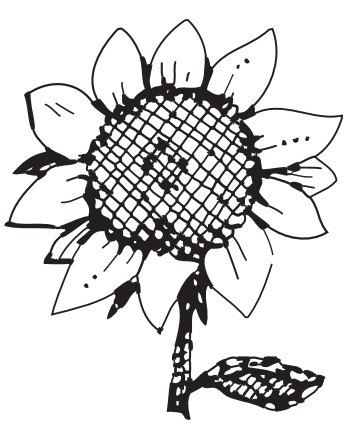
5 In your own words, write two reasons why plants need food.

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